Anil, set up the country's largest oil refinery plants, Gautam steadily acquired vast tracts of land in Mundra. By 2007, his acquisition totalled over 15,000 hectares spanning 40 km of coastline on which he would construct a state-of-the-art port with 26 berths, making it the largest port facility in the country.

THE ADANI WAY

The Mundra port provided a gateway for Adani to enter other businesses—power generation, since it owned large tracts of land and was a large importer of coal, a key input; the edible oil business as it used to import the commodity for Singapore's Wilmar, later forming a 50:50 joint venture with it; the transmission, distribution and renewables businesses since they were natural extensions of power, as was piped gas; airports and roads as an extension of the infrastructure story; and now cement, since it can use fly ash from Adani's power plants as feedstock. Today, the group owns or operates 12 ports across seven states and accounts for a quarter of the country's ports capacity. He is also India's largest airport operator, handling 25 per cent of the passenger traffic and 40 per cent of the air cargo, and its largest edible oils manufacturer. The group employs over a 100,000 people, both directly and indirectly, across the world.

The Mundra port experience would define the way Adani does business. One signature move was to align his business vision with the priorities of the government of the day. The second was to expand business by venturing into what he calls "adjacencies" or sectors complementary to his interests, which he also describes as "connecting the dots". He says, "Our thinking is clear as to how we can help the country. This aligns the businesses with the aspirations of the country and also gives our activities the required tailwind that makes for smooth sailing." Veteran investment banker Nimesh Kampani has been quoted saying, "Gautam Adani is an ideal example of an empire builder who did not owe his growth to any of the new-age technologies. Instead, he chose to be part of the development scene of the country and achieve success through the contributions he could make to society."

How does the cement acquisition, then, fit into his overall business ambitions? Adani explains that his business empire has two large verticals. On the one side are ports, logistics and airports, largely classified as ports and transport. On the other are energy and utilities. The energy portfolio houses the group's thermal plants, renewables, transmission, distribution, LNG terminals and city gas distribution. "We are increasing our positioning in every vertical, but at the same time with these different verticals standing together, we are creating 'adjacencies'. Cement is coming out of these adjacencies," he explains. The word, denoting the entry into businesses that have a "nearness" to existing business, has a close resonance with the policy of backward and forward integration followed by Reliance Industries founder Dhirubhai Ambani (whom Adani considers his 'inspiration'), while building his massive petrochemicals empire.



Mundra Port, the largest private port of India, on the north shores of the Gulf of Kutch in Gujarat

BETTING BIG ON GREEN ENERGY

The biggest push from Adani is coming in the green energy business. This again is in tandem with the Centre's plans to considerably scale up power generation from renewable sources. In 2015-16, the Narendra Modi government had committed to aggressive targets of installing 175 GW of renewable energy, excluding large hydro projects, by 2022. Of this, the targeted solar energy capacity was 100 GW by March 2023, 40 GW of which was to be rooftop solar and 60 GW ground-mounted. The targets were no doubt ambitious, but it has given Adani the fodder to fuel his green energy plans. Adani is clear that when the country's huge energy transition happens, it shouldn't be dependent on China and is setting up one of the most integrated green-energy value chains. The giga factories will extend from polysilicon to solar modules, complete manufacturing of wind turbines and the manufacturing of hydrogen electrolysers. "When we are in full command of the chain, we will see that India can produce the cheapest fuel electron in the world," he predicts. The factories will also help generate an additional 45 GW of renewable energy to add to the Adani Group's existing 20 GW capacity, as well as three million tonnes of hydrogen by 2030. Asked about the possibility of hydrogen energy becoming viable soon, he says, "The Indian government has brought out a very